

COURIER MANAGEMENT SYSTEM (CMS)

BRAINSTORMING & IDEATION

Project Phase Documentation

Project Information	Details
Project Name	Courier Management System (CMS)
Program Track	Salesforce Administrator with AI Agentforce (TN Skills / SmartBridge - Vetri Thiran Payarchi Thittam)
Institution	Mazharul Uloom College (Autonomous), Ambur, Tamil Nadu
Environment	Salesforce Developer Edition (Lightning Experience)
Team Lead	P. Mohammed Faiz
Team Members	Sayed Muhammed Mohathaseem; Mohammed Sufiyan A; T. Mohammed Azhan; M. G. Maaz
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Document Purpose

This document records the problem discovery, user understanding, brainstorming alternatives, solution selection, initial concept, scope boundaries and transition into the formal requirements phase of the Courier Management System.

1. Introduction to Brainstorming & Ideation

The Brainstorming & Ideation phase establishes the foundation of the Courier Management System before detailed Salesforce configuration begins. The project source identifies courier and logistics operations as being affected by manual processes and disconnected systems. These conditions make shipment tracking difficult, contribute to delayed updates and reduce customer visibility.

The purpose of this phase is to move from the broad operational problem to a clearly defined solution direction. The team first identifies who experiences the problem, what they are trying to accomplish, what prevents them from accomplishing it, and what a useful future state should provide.

1.1 Project Context

Area	Ideation Finding
Business domain	Courier and logistics operations involving customers, shipments, branches, delivery agents and billing.
Primary operational concern	Manual shipment tracking and disconnected systems.
Customer concern	Delayed updates and uncertainty about parcel progress.
Management concern	Difficulty managing shipments efficiently and monitoring operations.
Technology direction	A centralized Salesforce cloud solution.
Initial platform	Salesforce Lightning Experience using declarative configuration.

1.2 Why This Phase Matters

- Defines the problem before designing the solution.
- Identifies the people directly affected by courier-process limitations.
- Provides a basis for comparing possible solution approaches.
- Creates a shared understanding among the project team.
- Establishes the initial scope that is later converted into formal requirements.

1.3 Ideation Outcome

The output of this phase is a defined courier-management problem, identified user perspectives, a considered set of solution alternatives and a selected Salesforce-based solution concept. Detailed field definitions, formulas, flows, permissions and testing procedures belong to later project phases.

2. Problem Discovery & Problem Statements

The project source uses a Customer Problem Statement template to describe the difficulties from the perspectives of a Branch Manager and a Customer. This prevents the ideation process from beginning with technology and instead starts with the operational need.

2.1 Customer Problem Statements

ID	I am	I am trying to	But	Because	Which makes me feel
PS-1	Branch Manager	manage shipments efficiently	tracking is manual	systems are disconnected	stressed
PS-2	Customer	track parcels	updates are delayed	there is no centralized system	uncertain

2.2 Branch Manager Problem Analysis

The Branch Manager's objective is efficient shipment management. The documented barrier is manual tracking, with disconnected systems identified as the underlying reason. The problem therefore involves more than record keeping: it affects coordination, follow-up effort and operational visibility.

- Manual tracking requires repeated checking and follow-up.
- Disconnected systems make it difficult to maintain one consistent view of a shipment.
- Delivery coordination becomes harder when shipment and agent information are not connected.
- The desired outcome is efficient shipment management supported by centralized information.

2.3 Customer Problem Analysis

The Customer is trying to track parcels but experiences delayed updates because there is no centralized system. The source describes the resulting feeling as uncertainty. This makes customer visibility a core requirement of the concept.

- Customers need access to current shipment progress through the organization.
- Delayed updates can increase the need for customer-support follow-up.
- A centralized shipment record can provide a consistent source of status information for authorized users.

2.4 Core Problem Themes

Theme	Observed Problem	Implication for the Idea
Tracking	Manual tracking	Create structured digital tracking records.
Connectivity	Disconnected systems	Connect courier information in one platform.
Visibility	Delayed updates	Make shipment status easier to retrieve.
Coordination	Manual follow-ups	Connect agents, branches and shipments.
Management	Limited visibility	Prepare structured data for reporting.

3. Empathy Map Canvas

The project source identifies the Branch Manager as the primary persona for the empathy map. The purpose is to understand the operational experience of the person responsible for managing shipments rather than simply listing software features.

3.1 Branch Manager Persona

Empathy Dimension	Documented Observation	Design Meaning
Think & Feel	Concerned about delays & errors	The solution should improve operational visibility and reduce preventable errors.
Hear	Customer complaints	Customer communication pressure affects branch operations.
See	Registers & spreadsheets	Existing information is maintained through manual or fragmented records.
Say & Do	Manual follow-ups	The manager spends time checking and coordinating information.
Pain	Delivery conflicts & missed updates	The system should support coordination and event tracking.
Gain	Automated tracking & dashboards	Automation and analytics represent the desired future state.

3.2 Persona Narrative

The Branch Manager operates between customer expectations and delivery operations. The manager sees records maintained through registers or spreadsheets, hears complaints when shipment information is unavailable, and performs manual follow-ups to understand delivery progress. Delivery conflicts and missed updates are identified as major pains. The desired gains are automated tracking and dashboards.

3.3 Needs Derived from the Empathy Map

1. A single place to locate shipment information.
2. A structured relationship between shipments and delivery agents.
3. A reliable way to record delivery events.
4. A current shipment status that can be reviewed without searching multiple disconnected records.
5. Management dashboards that summarize structured operational information.

3.4 Customer Perspective

The detailed empathy map focuses on the Branch Manager, while the customer problem statement provides the customer perspective. Together, the two perspectives establish that the solution must support internal operational management and better access to shipment-status information.

4. Brainstorming of Solution Alternatives

Once the problem and user perspective were established, the project considered multiple solution directions. The documented alternatives range from continuing manual practices to adopting a centralized Salesforce CRM platform.

4.1 Ideas Considered

Alternative	Approach	Potential Value	Main Limitation
Manual registers	Continue using physical records.	Familiar and simple to start.	No centralized digital tracking, automation or analytics.
Spreadsheet tracking	Maintain shipment data in spreadsheets.	Digital records are easier to search and update than paper.	Still highly dependent on manual updates and coordination.
Standalone portal	Build a dedicated courier application.	Can provide a dedicated digital tracking experience.	Requires separate application infrastructure and operational integration.
Salesforce CRM	Use Salesforce as the centralized courier platform.	Supports automation, scalability and real-time visibility.	Requires Salesforce configuration and platform knowledge.

4.2 Evaluation Criteria

Criterion	Why It Matters
Automation	The project needs to reduce manual status-management work.
Scalability	The solution should support growth in records and branches.
Real-time visibility	Authorized users should be able to see current shipment progress.
Centralization	Customer, shipment, agent, branch, update and invoice data should be connected.
Maintainability	The documented core solution is intended to use Salesforce declarative configuration.

4.3 Brainstorming Discussion

Manual registers represent the existing operational approach but do not address the central visibility problem. Spreadsheet tracking improves digitization but still depends on manual maintenance and does not naturally create the integrated object relationships and automation required by the concept.

A standalone portal could provide a dedicated application, but the project selected Salesforce CRM because the documented selection criteria are automation, scalability and real-time visibility. The brainstorming process therefore moved from a generic courier-application idea toward a Salesforce-centered solution.

5. Idea Prioritization & Platform Selection

5.1 Comparative Prioritization

Idea	Automation Fit	Scalability Fit	Visibility Fit	Outcome
Manual registers	Low	Low	Low	Not selected
Spreadsheet tracking	Low	Limited	Limited	Not selected
Standalone portal	Potentially high	Potentially high	High	Considered, but not selected
Salesforce CRM	High	High	High	Selected platform

The comparison summarizes the documented project reasoning. The source explicitly states that Salesforce CRM was selected because it supports automation, scalability and real-time visibility.

5.2 Why Salesforce CRM

Salesforce CRM provides the project with a cloud platform in which operational records can be modeled as connected objects. The concept can use Salesforce Lightning for the user interface, validation rules for data quality, Flow for automation, profiles and roles for access control, and Reports and Dashboards for management visibility.

5.3 Initial Solution Concept

Capability	Initial Concept
Customer management	Maintain customer details in a centralized Customer record.
Shipment management	Maintain the central consignment record with tracking and delivery information.
Agent management	Maintain delivery-agent information and assignment relationships.
Branch management	Maintain regional hub information.
Tracking	Store delivery events in a Delivery Update record.
Billing	Maintain shipment-linked invoice information.
Automation	Use validation rules and Salesforce Flow.
Analytics	Use Salesforce Reports and Dashboards.
Security	Use profiles and roles to control access.

5.4 Ideation-to-Feature Traceability

Identified Need	Conceptual Feature
Manual shipment tracking	Shipment and Delivery Update records
Disconnected information	Related Salesforce custom objects
Delivery coordination	Delivery Agent and Branch relationships
Delayed visibility	Centralized shipment status and tracking events
Billing fragmentation	Invoice linked to Shipment
Limited management insight	Reports and Courier Management Dashboard
Access control	Profiles and role hierarchy

6. Proposed Operational Flow

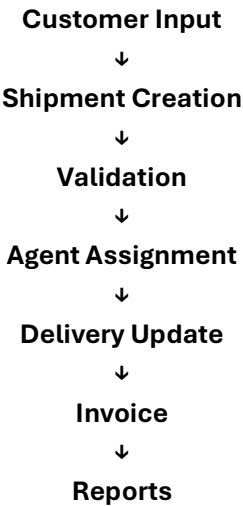
The ideation output naturally forms the high-level operational journey later documented in the requirements phase.

BOOKING → SHIPMENT CREATION → AGENT ASSIGNMENT → TRANSIT → DELIVERY UPDATE → INVOICE → REPORTING

6.1 Stage-by-Stage Concept

Stage	Conceptual Activity	Purpose
Booking	Capture customer and shipment request.	Starts the operational process.
Shipment Creation	Create the shipment record.	Creates a central shipment identity.
Agent Assignment	Associate a delivery agent.	Connects delivery responsibility to the shipment.
Transit	Record delivery progress.	Maintains movement information.
Delivery Update	Record status and update information.	Provides the basis for tracking visibility.
Invoice	Create shipment-related billing information.	Connects financial processing to the shipment.
Reporting	Aggregate operational information.	Supports management analysis.

6.2 High-Level Data Flow



6.3 Initial User Roles

Role	Ideation-Level Responsibility
Courier Admin	Overall administration and system control.
Branch Manager	Manage branch operations, shipments and delivery agents.
Delivery Agent	Update delivery progress and status.
Customer Support	Handle customer information and tracking queries.

6.4 Boundaries of Ideation

- The ideation phase does not define every Salesforce field or API name.
- It does not define final validation formulas.
- It does not define the complete Flow implementation.

- It does not define every profile or field-level security setting.
- It does not define detailed test execution.

These decisions belong to later project phases. This separation keeps the project traceable from problem discovery to requirements, design, development and testing.

7. Scope, Assumptions & Constraints

7.1 Initial In-Scope Direction

Area	Initial Direction
Data	Customer, Shipment, Delivery Agent, Branch, Delivery Update and Invoice.
Automation	Validation rules and record-triggered shipment-status automation.
Application	Salesforce Lightning app, custom tabs and page layouts.
Security	Profiles, roles and users for defined user groups.
Analytics	Reports and a Courier Management Dashboard.
Testing	Functional verification with screenshot evidence.
Documentation	User guide and deployment checklist.

7.2 Future Scope

Future Capability	Reason Kept Outside Initial Release
Mobile tracking application	Not part of the documented initial Salesforce web application.
GPS / live location integration	Requires additional location-tracking capability.
SMS/email customer notifications	Not included in the documented release.
AI route optimization	Identified as a future enhancement.
Customer self-service portal	Not included in the initial application.
Payment gateway integration	Online payment collection is outside the documented release.
External ERP/accounting integration	External integration is outside the initial configuration.

7.3 Assumptions & Constraints

- The system is designed for Salesforce Developer Edition with limited user licenses.
- Users access Salesforce Lightning Experience through a web browser and internet connectivity.
- Customer notifications are not automated in the documented release; Customer Support relays status when asked.
- Invoice amounts are entered or copied by staff; no automatic tax or discount engine is documented.

7.4 Ideation Success Criteria

Success Criterion	Evidence Produced
Problem clearly defined	Two customer problem statements.
Primary persona identified	Branch Manager empathy map.
Alternatives considered	Four solution approaches.
Selection rationale recorded	Automation, scalability and real-time visibility.
Initial solution defined	Salesforce CRM / Lightning concept.
Boundaries established	Initial scope and future-scope list.
Next-phase foundation created	User flow, data flow and feature mapping.

8. Team Ideation & Decision Record

The project is a team-based academic Salesforce implementation led by P. Mohammed Faiz. The ideation phase provides a shared foundation for the later Agile planning and implementation activities.

8.1 Team

Member	Project Role
P. Mohammed Faiz	Team Lead
Sayed Muhammed Mohathaseem	Team Member
Mohammed Sufiyan A	Team Member
T. Mohammed Azhan	Team Member
M. G. Maaz	Team Member

8.2 Recommended Ideation Collaboration Sequence

6. Identify courier-process pain points.
7. Write problem statements from user perspectives.
8. Map the Branch Manager's thoughts, observations, actions, pains and gains.
9. List possible solution approaches before selecting a platform.
10. Compare alternatives using the project selection criteria.
11. Select the solution direction.
12. Record initial scope and future enhancements.
13. Transfer the ideation output to Requirement Analysis.

8.3 Final Decision Record

Decision Area	Recorded Outcome
Primary operational problem	Manual and disconnected courier operations.
Primary persona	Branch Manager.
Additional affected user	Customer.
Candidate solutions	Manual registers, spreadsheets, standalone portal, Salesforce CRM.
Selected platform	Salesforce CRM.
Selection factors	Automation, scalability and real-time visibility.
Application direction	Salesforce Lightning Courier Management System.

9. Conclusion

The Brainstorming & Ideation phase transforms the initial courier-management challenge into a defined project concept. The documented problem statements establish that Branch Managers need more efficient shipment management while customers need more reliable parcel visibility.

The empathy map adds operational context by identifying delays, errors, complaints, registers, spreadsheets, manual follow-ups, delivery conflicts and missed updates. Brainstorming then considers four alternatives and selects Salesforce CRM based on the documented criteria of automation, scalability and real-time visibility.

The resulting concept is a centralized Salesforce Lightning Courier Management System connecting customers, shipments, delivery agents, branches, delivery updates and invoices, with automation, security and analytics introduced in later phases.

10. Transition to Requirement Analysis

The next phase converts the ideation output into formal system requirements. The documented customer journey is Booking → Shipment Creation → Agent Assignment → Transit → Delivery Update → Invoice → Reporting. This creates a direct bridge from the question 'What problem are we solving?' to the question 'What must the system do?'